



epsom1u3a@gmail.com

Website <https://u3aepsom.nz/>.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga
10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

May 2026

Next meeting
10-12noon
Thursday 14 May 2026

Welcome everyone

In the last month, I've viewed an exhibition of jugs modelled on notable New Zealand paintings (I know what you're thinking ... but surprisingly good), discussed the role of the MAGA movement in modern American religion, played a couple of good games of chess, and listened to a fascinating talk about how Ernest Rutherford made his way from a Nelson high school to the most advanced physics laboratory in the world and won the Nobel prize. I've met a guy who has chased tornados in the United States and sailed to Antarctica, and I've enjoyed the company and hospitality of people I've met over the past two years.

All this within the auspices of the U3A. We really do live up to the description of the U3A's purpose on the national website: "focus is on lifelong learning, and active participation in a wide range of interest groups. Plus, along the way having a chance to laugh and live in the moment together."

We've spoken recently on whether our organisation can be improved. I think it's good to ask these questions of ourselves even though the feedback I'm receiving seems to indicate a widespread satisfaction of what we've already got. If so, that's great but, sometime in the next few weeks, we will give everyone the opportunity to have a say.

One final word – beware of scammers. As you may have heard, there are scam emails about in both Duncan's name and mine. Be assured – no one from the U3A committee will *ever* ask you for money, pressie cards or anything like it – never.

Keep warm as winter starts to bite!

Ian Jost

EPSOM U3A EXECUTIVE

President

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037
president.u3aepsom@gmail.com

Immediate Past President:

Duncan MacDonald – 021 316 661

General Duties

Kaye Buchanan- 620 7572

Secretary

Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487
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Minutes Secretary

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Almoner

Charmaine Strang – 027 4177 556

Interest Group Co-ordinators

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Bill Hagan – 021 611 247

Guest Speaker Organiser:

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037

Legal Advisor

Mike Matson – 022 630 7968

Newsletter

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Greeters:

Don Buchanan - 620 7572

Ngaira Mune – 624 0226

Helen Dallaston - 022-2647786

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences

Peter Parsons - 021 521446

Attending Performing Arts

Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662

Architecture

Brian Murray – 021 026 68396

Art Appreciation

Kaye Buchanan – 620 7572

Art History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Big History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Book Chat

Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510

Chess Group

John Locke - 021-187 8061

Comparative Religions

Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661

John Locke- 021-187 8061

Current Affairs

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Fabric & Fibre Crafts

Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556

Famous & Infamous Group

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Foodies

Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.

Garden Appreciation

Betty Townley - 626 6673

Introduction to Family History

Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235

Latin

Phyllis Downes – 630 5867

Lunch Bunch

Shirley McConville – 622 3542.

Music Appreciation

Carleen Edwards – 624 6298

History & Social Change

Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510

NZ History

Kaye Buchanan - 620 7572

Philosophy

Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552

Scrabble

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Te Reo Maori

Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487

Travel

Diana Hart- 021 284 4402

Walkers & Talkers Group

Don Buchanan ph:620 7572.

APRIL SPEAKER REPORT

In April we were treated to a fascinating talk by an intrepid adventurer, Peter Wharton, who has the distinction of having chased storms in the USA, travelled to base camp on Mt Everest and sailed through some of the wildest parts of the world's oceans, to remote places including the Falklands Islands, the Drake passage and Antarctica.

His enthusiastic talk was accompanied by stunning photographs of rough seas, icebergs, wildlife and beautiful icy or snowy vistas. His talk focussed on his 33-day, 3000 nautical mile journey in 2013 in the barque "Europa", a 3 masted square-rigged barque built in 1911 – a ship designed with a strengthened steel hull to deal with the huge seas and icefields of Antarctica. Today the ship is fitted out with extreme safety gear and Zodiac boats to allow the travellers to go on land-based expeditions. – but no power winches. The crew has to use muscle power, just like the old days.

Peter was first attracted to the Antarctic trip, after visiting a tall ships' display in Auckland Harbour, which offered 20% off the journey. The candidates for this journey, from many varied walks of life and 15 nationalities, had to pass extensive medical checks and give insurance guarantees before being allowed to participate. The route included departing via Santiago, Chile, Punta Arenas, then on to the Falklands, South Georgia, the Southern Orkneys, the Shetlands, then to Antarctica, a distance as great as circumnavigating NZ.

After leaving Port Stanley harbour, many of the travellers, who had not yet found their "sea-legs", were seasick, as the waves crashed over the decks and the ship heeled over in the enormous 10 metre swells, produced by powerful winds. Safety harnesses needed to be worn on deck, as the 31 crew and 15 visitors carried out their watches, in three rotating teams. Special clothing was needed to keep warm and dry, and when near snow and ice, protective sunglasses were required due to the reflective glare from the sun on the white surfaces.

Sailing on the "Europa" he described the experience of becoming a crewmember, not a passenger. Everyone became one of the three watch teams which ran the ship in four-hour sessions. While they had plenty of modern safety gear on board, there were no power winches. The ship was sailed old-style with many hands pulling on ropes. One day they had a "Man overboard" drill where it took four minutes to lower the sails and a full seven minutes to recover the fender tossed into the sea. With water temperatures around 2.6C, survival would have been doubtful.

The Antarctic Circumpolar Current stretches 30,000km around the continent. As the ship passed the Antarctic Convergence, the water became less saline, colder (about 2.6C) and full of rich nutrients and krill to support life. This is the most biologically diverse area of the Southern Ocean and is home to millions of sea-birds (eg skua, shags and albatrosses), Gentoo and King penguins, and mammals such as fur seals, and elephant seals. There are strict rules to protect the ecology of the area, with limits to tourism, and visitors have to disinfect their boots and gear. No drones are permitted. Zodiac boats are used to go ashore for exploration. Because it was a small vessel (300 tons and only 56m long), they were actually able to go onshore in S Georgia – where cruise liners were forbidden.

Life forms also include tussock grasses and green mosses, as seen in Whale Bay. Peter was lucky enough to be able to trace the famous explorer Ernest Shackleton's expedition route, but this time in the summer, by motor-boat. He also spoke about the millions of seals and whales that were caught and processed, beginning in 1776, and whaling was not abandoned until the mid-twentieth century. Over 1.5 million whales were taken over this period of time, their blubber used for lubricants, fuel for oil lamps, pharmaceuticals and cosmetics, and their bone used for buttons, combs, instruments etc. The introduced rats and reindeer have now been eradicated so the wildlife is regenerating.

On the later part of the journey the ship encountered glaciers, icebergs, humpback and fin whales and giant kelp that grows 30 metres down to the sea floor. On reaching ice fields, the sails would be taken down and the ship would motor carefully and slowly through the obstacle course.

Life was sociable on board, with daily briefings, a Christmas party, a BBQ on the deck for New Year and there were lessons in seamanship. (eg. rigging and setting the sails, tying knots). Peter says that lifelong friendships were forged and the trip was an unforgettable experience.

MAY SPEAKER	<u>Our speaker for May is Jen Calius</u> Jen is a Donor Coordinator Nurse Specialist for Organ Donation New Zealand, which is part of the NZ Blood Service. That organisation works closely with Intensive Care units and operating theatres all over New Zealand and Australia to facilitate organ and tissue donation, and support donor families through the process – as well as for the years beyond their loved one's donation. Organ Donation NZ is also involved in education and public awareness. Jen herself has a background in intensive care, emergency and telehealth nursing. Jen will be talking about organ and tissue donation in New Zealand - what organs and tissues can be donated, why these are needed and the impact of transplantation. She will also talk about the various pathways to donation. The newest pathway enables people who have chosen assisted dying to have the option of donation. Jen will share some donor and transplant recipient stories, and burst some myths and misconceptions. She will also briefly cover legislation and ethical considerations.
POTENTIAL MINI SPEAKERS	Remember Shirley and Grant's presentation at the last meeting? If you'd like to stand up and say anything at all, please do. We need members prepared to stand up and talk for five minutes or so – on any topic of general interest. This may be a description of an existing Interest Group, or a suggestion about starting a new one. It may be a sharing of significant Community News, u3a news, recent developments in the field of health & fitness, hobbies, IT topics etc etc. The element of the unexpected could be good- anything from local events to new recipes, scam alerts to volunteering opportunities.
BOOK SALE 21-24 MAY	'Books, Bagels and Banter' is being held on 21-24 May at St Andrews Church Hall. There will be plenty of well-presented and categorised, secondhand books for sale, and interesting speakers. It's a community fundraiser event that would benefit from as much support as possible. https://www.standrewsepsom.org.nz/books-bagels-banter/
INTEREST GROUPS	In the days before Covid, there was a Stories of the Past group which met monthly and exchanged family stories – the kind you always mean to write down but seldom actually get around to doing. We used to put out an annual booklet for the group with a story from each member. If there are people interested in restarting it, I would be happy to convene and host it again. Jeanette Grant
EXCHANGE TABLE	Reminder. If you bring material to the exchange table and no-one selects it, please make sure you take it home with you at the end of the meeting.
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	14 May 11 June 9 July 13 August 10 September 8 October 12 November AGM NB Always wear your name badge and be seated ready at 10am

u3a Auckland Network welcomes you to a day of celebration

Salvation Army Church, 18 Allright Place, Mt Wellington
Saturday 25 July 2026 - 9:30am (for 10:00am) to 2:30pm

Speakers:

Morning: Dame Wendy Pye - "Teaching the World to Read."

Afternoon: Shamubeel Eaqub - "A Society Worth Having."

Also included are four presentations by u3a Members and lunch - \$50.00

Go to u3a.nz/event to register

A LOST SUPER-CIVILISATION?

An Egyptologist is making the case that the Great Pyramids were built by an advanced civilization thousands of years earlier than previously thought.

António Ambrósio, an independent researcher from the Autonomous University of Barcelona, detailed the mysterious clues that point to the three main pyramids at Giza being up to 12,000 years old, predating the Egyptians by millennia. If Ambrósio's theory were to be proven correct, it would rewrite the history of modern humans and expose the existence of a still-unknown 'supercivilization' on Earth that constructed pyramids and other megastructures around the world.

At the heart of the researcher's case are a set of key inconsistencies Ambrósio and other scholars have claimed as proof that the Egyptians only copied the original three pyramids after discovering the ancient structures at Giza.

The new paper, which has not been peer-reviewed, argued that no royal mummies or burial items have ever been found inside the Giza pyramids, despite the ancient Egyptians claiming these were the tombs of Khufu, Khafre and Menkaure. Moreover, the original Giza pyramids, currently believed to have been built 4,600 years ago, displayed stunning engineering skill that aligned with star constellations, featured super-precise stone cuts and had a base that was almost perfectly level on all sides.

Ambrósio explained that these incredible engineering feats were never matched by any of the smaller pyramids confirmed to have been built during the time of the Egyptians between 2500 and 2150 BC. The researcher added that the nearby statue of the Sphinx has shown signs of water erosion from heavy rain, which hasn't happened in Egypt since around 5000 to 3000 BC, suggesting that the entire site was already ancient and eroding at the dawn of the Egyptian civilization in 3100 BC.

OMNIVORES = CENTENARIANS?

Vegan and vegetarian diets might seem like the healthy choice, but scientists now say that avoiding meat could scupper your chances of reaching 100.

According to a major Chinese study, meat eaters are actually more likely to reach the milestone age than their plant-eating counterparts. Even after accounting for factors like exercise and smoking, people who cut meat out of their diet were 19 per cent less likely to make it to 100 compared to omnivores.

This trend was the most pronounced among vegans, who are a staggering 29 per cent less likely to become centenarians. Vegetarians, who still eat eggs and dairy, were only slightly more likely to make it to 100, with their odds being 14 per cent worse than those of meat eaters. Even trendy pescetarian diets, which include fish, were linked with reduced odds of reaching 100.

The researchers suggest that these stark differences could be because older people need more nutrients than vegetarian diets can provide.

Lead author Dr Xiang Gao, of Fudan University, says: *'Our study suggests that in adults aged 80 years and older, a diet including both plant and animal-derived foods may better support survival to 100 years than a strictly vegetarian pattern, especially for those who are underweight.'*

MYSTERIOUS SUNKEN 'CITY'

A team of explorers believed they discovered an ancient sunken city that would rewrite human history, but the ruins have mysteriously been ignored for 25 years.

In 2001, marine engineer Paulina Zelitsky and her husband, Paul Weinzwieg, from Advanced Digital Communications (ADC), revealed that they had stumbled upon a collection of stone structures over 2,000 feet underwater near Cuba. Sonar scans of the area showed what looked like multiple pyramids, circular structures, and other buildings that seemed to belong to a lost city in the Caribbean.

'It's a really wonderful structure which really looks like it could have been a large urban center,' Zelitsky said after the discovery.

Researchers suggested that the mysterious city could be more than 6,000 years old, making it significantly older than the Egyptian pyramids and potentially upending the currently accepted timeline of human development. However, an even bigger mystery unfolded after the discovery: no one ever went back to examine the alleged lost city in more than two decades. One factor that has held back further research has been the fact that fellow scientists have continued to voice their scepticism about the sunken city, saying it would have taken up to 50,000 years for a city to sink that far underwater. Other critics have contended that the 'structures' are natural rock formations, arguing that an entire city wouldn't have been so well preserved if it sank during a catastrophic seismic disaster...In 2002, Iturralde noted that the structures were so deep underwater, it would have taken much longer than 6,000 years for this area to sink nearly half a mile due to shifting tectonic plates.

WOULD WOOD WORK?

Japan is preparing to launch the world's first wooden satellite, LignoSat, later this year. Made from magnolia wood, the satellite aims to tackle the growing issue of space pollution, particularly the aluminum particles released when traditional metal satellites burn up during re-entry.

Developed by researchers from Kyoto University in collaboration with Sumitomo Forestry, the LignoSat project explores the potential of biodegradable materials to replace the metals traditionally used in satellite construction. Wood samples tested on the International Space Station (ISS) were exposed to space conditions for nearly a year and showed little to no signs of degradation. Murata explained this by the lack of oxygen and living organisms in space, which would normally cause wood to decompose on Earth.

LignoSat will undergo similar tests once launched, providing further insights into how wood performs under the extreme temperatures, vacuum, and radiation of space.

TERRIBLE TEHERAN

More than 15 million people now live in a city originally designed for just 2 million, overwhelming water systems, power grids, and transportation networks. Air pollution regularly reaches hazardous levels and has been linked to thousands of deaths each year, while reservoirs feeding the capital have dropped to historic lows. With corruption scandals, sanctions, and rapid population growth compounding the crisis, Iran's capital is facing a breakdown of infrastructure that millions depend on daily.

It was once called 'The Paris of the Middle East.'

STRONG SPIDERS' SILK

A spider no larger than a coin has upended what scientists thought they knew about natural materials. Discovered in the wilds of Madagascar, Darwin's bark spider spins silk tougher than Kevlar, a very strong synthetic fiber, setting a new benchmark for biological strength.

According to a study, published in *The Journal of Arachnology*, the spider builds enormous orb webs across rivers and streams, suspending them on lines more than 80 feet long. Its silk doesn't just hold, it absorbs energy more efficiently than any known natural or synthetic material. Darwin's bark spider constructs webs that can stretch over 30 square feet, suspended in midair over rivers. As reported by *The Journal of Arachnology*, no other eight-legged predator is known to routinely build in such locations, several meters above water, anchored to trees on opposite shores.

This positioning means the webs must endure wind, tension, and the struggles of prey. Igni Agnarsson and Matjaž Kuntner noted that the spiders likely shoot threads across the water, catching them on branches to form the base of the web. Once anchored, they weave the rest of the structure. While some other web-spinners build near water, none have been documented creating such extensive webs over open air. The demands of this habitat likely drove the evolution of their extraordinary silk, built to withstand not just force but time....

Elasticity plays a central role. The silk stretches twice as far as that of other orb-weaving spiders before snapping. This allows the web to remain intact as prey struggle, storing and dissipating energy without breaking. The molecular structure responsible for these remarkable qualities remains unknown, though the two experts suggest that future research may reveal what makes this silk so exceptionally effective.

TREES SURROUND TAKLAMAKAN DESERT

On November 28, 2024, crews on the southern rim of the Taklamakan Desert planted the last 100 meters of trees. Chinese state reporting said the final stretch completed a 3,046-kilometer green belt encircling the desert in Xinjiang, turning decades of incremental planting into a continuous perimeter...

The effort is a major chapter inside China's Three-North Shelterbelt Program, launched in 1978 and widely known as the Great Green Wall. Completion did not mean the desert stopped moving. Keeping a planted perimeter intact in shifting-sand conditions has required repeated repair work as gaps open and saplings fail, especially where dunes migrate fastest and water is hardest to secure...

The barrier was never pitched as a climate experiment. It was built to slow dune movement near roads, farms, and settlements, and to blunt dust that can travel far beyond the basin. The urgency behind that logic has been visible for generations in communities where sand can overwhelm pasture and swallow newly exposed ground. The Taklamakan case now sits at an unusual intersection of climate metrics and landscape engineering...

Although the belt was built to slow sand movement and protect human infrastructure, the newest analysis quantifies an additional effect: seasonal carbon uptake along the vegetated rim that is large enough to show up in long-term datasets. The project's future, and any attempt to repeat it elsewhere, will hinge on whether that biological gain can be sustained where water remains the limiting resource.